

17 Reported questions

In this unit we will practise changing questions into **reported speech**.

17.1 Reporting verbs

When we report questions, the reporting verb is *ask*, not *say*. Look at the picture below.



We can report the woman's question this way:

The woman *asked* the lost little girl **what her name was**.

or

The woman *asked* the lost little girl **her name**.

Other reporting verbs that we use include *wonder*, *inquire*, *query*, *want to know*, *try to find out*, etc.

Direct: 'Why is it wrong?' she **asked** herself.

Reported: She **wondered** why it was wrong.

There are two types of questions: **wh-questions** (questions beginning with question words such as *who*, *where*, *when*, *what*, *which*, *how*, etc.) and **yes/no questions**. We change these two types of questions into **reported speech** differently.

17.2 Reported *wh*-questions

When we report a *wh*-question, we

- keep the question word

Direct: '**Where** did you buy your cap?' Nathan asked me.

Reported: Nathan asked me **where** I had bought my cap.

- change the word order to **subject + verb**

Compare:

	Example	Word order
Direct speech	'How does it work? ' he asked me.	verb + subject
Reported speech	✓ He asked me how it worked . ✗ He asked me how did it work.	subject + verb

- end the sentence with a full stop, not a question mark
- change the verb tense, pronouns, references to time and place, etc. in the same way as we do for reported statements

Direct: 'Who **left** an umbrella at **my** home **yesterday?**' she asked.

Reported: She asked who **had left** an umbrella at **her** home **the day before**.

17.3 Reported *yes/no* questions

Now look at this example:

Direct: '**Are you a student?**' the shop assistant asked me.

Reported: The shop assistant *asked* me **if/whether I was a student**.

You can see that the reported **yes/no question** begins with *if* or *whether*. Except for this, the rest of the changes are the same as those made to *wh*-questions (i.e., word order, tense, pronouns, etc.).

Direct: '**Will your sister go to our school next September?**' Harry asked Ron.

Reported: Harry asked Ron **if/whether his sister would go to their school the following September**.



Note

We omit *do/does/did* if the question begins with one of these words.

Direct: '**Do you often shop online?**' Peter asked Leo.

Reported: Peter asked Leo **if/whether he often shops/shopped online**.

PRACTICE

A Change the following direct questions into **reported questions**.

- 1 Kate to Henry: 'Where do you live?'

Kate asked Henry where he lived.

- 2 Sonia to her mother: 'What are you cooking?'

Sonia asked her mother what she was cooking.

- 3 Peter to Calvin: 'How will you celebrate Christmas?'

Peter asked Calvin how he would celebrate Christmas.

- 4 Kenneth to his father: 'How long did the First World War last?'

Kenneth asked his father how long the First World War had lasted.

- 5 Susan to Jessica: 'Who sent you flowers?'

Susan asked Jessica who had sent her flowers.

- 6 The interviewer to Frank: 'Why are you interested in this position?'

Interviewer asked Frank why he was interested in the/that position.

- 7 Vincent to Wendy: 'What kind of food do you like?'

Vincent asked Wendy what kind of food she likes/liked.

- 8 Janice to a classmate: 'How much time do you spend on social media every day?'

Janice asked a classmate how much time he/she spends/spent on social media every day.

B Your family and friends asked you the following questions yesterday:

Sister	Did you <i>see</i> my keys?
Sam	Are you free tonight?
The class monitor	Have you handed in your homework?
Oscar	Will you play football with me after school?
Father	Have you posted the letter?
Jennifer	Did you go to Cheung Chau to see the parade yesterday?
Mother	Are you doing your homework?
Grandma	Will you visit me this Sunday?

Now, you are having dinner with Ada. Tell her what these people asked you yesterday. The first one has been done for you as an example.

- 1 My sister asked me if/whether I had seen her keys.
- 2 Sam asked me if/whether I was free last night.
- 3 The class monitor asked me if/whether I had handed in my homework.
- 4 Oscar asked me if/whether I would play football with him after school.
- 5 My father asked me if/whether I had posted the letter.
- 6 Jennifer asked me if/whether I had been to Cheung Chau to see the parade the day before/two days ago
_____.
- 7 My mother asked me if/whether I was doing my homework.
- 8 My grandma asked me if/whether I would visit her this Sunday.



Change the following direct questions into **reported questions**. The first one has been done for you as an example.

- 1 'What's wrong with my dog?' Newton asked the vet.

Newton asked the vet what was wrong with his dog.

- 2 'Are you feeling cold?' Leon asked Catherine.

Leon asked Catherine if/whether she was feeling cold.

- 3 'How far is the Star Ferry Pier from here?' the tourist asked Peggy.

The tourist asked Peggy how far the Star Ferry Pier was from there.

- 4 'May I take a photo of you?' the reporter asked the man.

The reporter asked the man if/whether he/she might take a photo of him.

- 5 'Do your grandparents live with you?' Kenny asked Lina.

Kenny asked Lina if/whether her grandparents live/lived with her.

- 6 'Did you talk to Ivan about this?' Daisy asked John.

Daisy asked John if/whether he had talked to Ivan about that/it.

- 7 'Who is your brother dating?' Ann asked Ken.

Ann asked Ken who his brother was dating.

- 8 'When did the robbery occur?' the policeman asked the witness.

The policeman asked the witness when the robbery had occurred.

D Look at the pictures and complete the story by filling in the missing parts. The first one has been done for you as an example.

You are a smart businessman, Joe. What's the secret of your success?

Well, brains, my friend, brains!



Joe is a smart businessman. One day he was having dinner with his friend Gordon. During the meal, Gordon asked Joe ⁽¹⁾ what the secret of his success was. Joe smiled and told him that it was brains.

Gordon wanted to know ⁽²⁾ how he could have brains like Joe had/Joe's. Joe advised him

⁽³⁾ to listen to Mozart and asked

Gordon ⁽⁴⁾ to give him \$500.

Gordon was surprised. He asked Joe what the money was for.

How can I have brains like you do?

\$500? What for?

You should listen to Mozart. Give me \$500.



A friend has sent me a special CD of Mozart's music, and it helps improve the brain. If you give me \$500, I'll get you the same CD that my friend gave me.



Joe explained that ⁽⁵⁾ a friend had sent him a special CD of Mozart's music. He said that

⁽⁶⁾ it helped improve the brain.

With that money, Joe said, he would get the same CD for Gordon.

Gordon was in doubt. He asked Joe ⁽⁷⁾ if it worked

Joe told him that ⁽⁸⁾ it worked for him

Does it work?

It works for me.



All right, here you are. When can I have the CD?

Meet me here at the same time tomorrow.



At last Gordon agreed to pay. He asked Joe

(9) when he could have the CD.

Joe told him (10) to meet him there at the same time the next day.

A week later the two friends met again. Joe asked

Gordon (11) how he (had) liked the music

_____. Gordon replied that

(12) it was/had been beautiful.

How did you like the music?

Oh, it was beautiful.



Do you feel different in any way?

No, I don't think so. In fact, I think it was a waste of money paying \$500 for just one CD.



Joe went on to ask Gordon (13) if he felt different in any

way. Gordon answered that

(14) he didn't think so. He added that he

regretted (15) paying \$500 for just one CD.

On hearing this, Joe became excited. He told Gordon

(16) (that) his brain was beginning to work better already

There you are! Your brain is beginning to work better already!



E Complete the following conversation using the correct forms of the verbs given in brackets.

Randy Hi Miranda, I heard that you had an interview for a summer job yesterday. What kind of job is it? And how was the interview?

Miranda It's an internship for a local newspaper. I suppose the interview ⁽¹⁾ went (*go*) well enough.

Randy It's good to hear that. What kind of questions did they ask you?

Miranda They asked me why I ⁽²⁾ was (*be*) interested in the job. I said that I ⁽³⁾ loved (*love*) writing about current affairs and I ⁽⁴⁾ enjoyed (*enjoy*) interviewing people.

Randy Did they ask you if you ⁽⁵⁾ had done (*do*) anything similar at school?

Miranda Oh, yes, they did. I replied that I ⁽⁶⁾ had worked (*work*) for a school magazine as a columnist the previous school year. I also told them that at the beginning of this school year I ⁽⁷⁾ became (*become*) one of the magazine's editors. Then they asked me if I ⁽⁸⁾ could show (*can/show*) them some sample articles that I ⁽⁹⁾ had written (*write*). Luckily I ⁽¹⁰⁾ had brought (*bring*) some with me, so I showed them. They ⁽¹¹⁾ included (*include*) a light-hearted interview with our headmaster.

Randy That's cool! What did they think about the articles?

Miranda I think they liked them. One of the interviewers said that I ⁽¹²⁾ had (*have*) a witty, humorous writing style. She said that my style ⁽¹³⁾ fitted (*fit*) the features section of the newspaper. What's more, another interviewer asked me which section of a newspaper that ⁽¹⁴⁾ interested (*interest*) me most.

Randy What did you say?

Miranda I answered that I ⁽¹⁵⁾ liked (*like*) sports, education and feature sections most. They seemed to like my answers. They even asked me if I ⁽¹⁶⁾ was willing (*be willing*) to start working as soon as the school term ended.

Randy That sounds promising! I think you're going to get the job.

Miranda Thank you! I hope so. I liked the people I met there too.

F Help Kenneth complete a letter of complaint using the information in the dialogue. Use **reported speech**. The first one has been done for you as an example.

- | | |
|---------------------------------|--|
| Kenneth | I have joined your group tour because the promised itinerary included three theme parks. But now you say the itinerary has been changed and it now includes only one theme park. Why did your company make the change? |
| Customer service officer | I'm very sorry, sir. We have made the change because some of the theme parks have not responded to our request for group tickets. |
| Kenneth | All right then. Can you arrange for me to join another group tour? I'm going to take my seven-year-old daughter along. She wants to have fun in theme parks. She won't be interested in sightseeing. |
| Customer service officer | I'm afraid it can't be done, sir. The other group tours are all full. |
| Kenneth | Well then, can I cancel my booking? When can I get a refund? |
| Customer service officer | Sorry, sir. According to the tour contract, your booking can't be cancelled, and the tour fee you have paid is not refundable. |
| Kenneth | What? Why didn't you tell me that when I signed the contract? |
| Customer service officer | But it's all written in the contract, sir. |
| Kenneth | You didn't even give me time to read everything when I signed it! |
| Customer service officer | I'm sorry about the situation, sir, but I can't do anything about it. |
| Kenneth | This is unacceptable! |

Dear Sir/Madam

On 23 June, I booked a group tour to Japan at your travel agency which promised three theme parks. A week later, your company told me that ⁽¹⁾ the itinerary had been changed, and that the new itinerary ⁽²⁾ included only one theme park. I asked one of your staff members ⁽³⁾ why your company had made the change. He replied that ⁽⁴⁾ they had made the changes because some of the theme parks had not responded to your request for group tickets.

It was a very disappointing situation, but I tried to be understanding. I asked him ⁽⁵⁾ if he could arrange for me to join another group tour. I explained that ⁽⁶⁾ I was going to take my seven-year-old daughter along. I added that she ⁽⁷⁾ wanted to have fun in theme parks and she ⁽⁸⁾ would not/wouldn't be interested in sightseeing.

However, your staff member answered that it could not be done. He explained that ⁽⁹⁾ the other group tours were all full.

I decided that I did not want to join a sightseeing tour. As a result, I asked your staff member ⁽¹⁰⁾ if I could cancel my booking. I also asked ⁽¹¹⁾ when I could get a refund. However, I was told that according to the signed contract, my booking could not be cancelled and the tour fee ⁽¹²⁾ I had paid was not refundable. I thought that it was an unfair deal. I asked your staff member ⁽¹³⁾ why he had not told me that when I signed the contract. He only apologized and said that ⁽¹⁴⁾ he could not/couldn't do anything about it.

I find this situation completely unacceptable. To resolve my problem, I would appreciate it if you give me a refund or make other reasonable arrangements for me. I look forward to your reply.

Yours faithfully

Kenneth Ng

USING THE LANGUAGE

We use **reported questions** to talk about questions people have asked without quoting their exact words. We can use them in, for example, a web post to tell others about a conversation with someone. We can also use them in an email to talk about questions asked in an interview, for instance. Look at the examples below. Note the uses of **reported questions** in bold.

Web post (excerpt)

Sometimes my smartphone assistant could be really funny. Just then I asked it **how many calories there were in a pizza**. Guess what its answer was? It didn't answer me! It simply asked me **why I wanted to have a pizza when I was on a diet**. I couldn't give an answer, so I asked it **whether I should have something healthier**. 'Of course!' it told me. It made me laugh so hard.

Email (excerpt)

Hi Tim

You asked **what questions the interviewers asked me**. Well, they asked me **why I wanted** the job. They also asked me **what my strengths and weaknesses were**. Oh, and they asked me **what experience I had** and **what I had learnt** from it. Before the end, they asked me **where I might see** myself in five or ten years. Hope this helps!



Your teacher asks you to write a web post about an unusual conversation you had to practise using **reported questions**. Begin with the given words. Do not write more than 120 words.

I had a weird conversation today. Someone came up to me on the street and asked me how I was doing. I was baffled because I didn't know her, so I asked her **if we knew each other**. **She said of course!** **She asked me whether I remembered Primary 1.** Then she said we were in the same class! I was really impressed that she remembered. I asked her who the teacher had been. She said, 'Ms Lam'. I said I had never had a teacher called Ms Lam. She asked me if I was sure. I told her yes. Then I asked her which primary school she had gone to. 'North Point Primary School,' she answered. 'I lived and studied in Sheung Shui when I was small,' I told her. **She was so embarrassed!**

(accept any reasonable answer)